

How You Got Happiness?

J. Krishnamurti

A nonlinear book on happiness, fear, attention, relationship, meditation, and freedom from
J. Krishnamurti's official talks and dialogues
Lecture notes organized by [LazyingArt LLC](#) with [Video2Book](#)

Original talks and dialogues by J. Krishnamurti. Source material preserved by the Krishnamurti Foundation Trust. Notes organized by [LazyingArt LLC](#) with [Video2Book](#).

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Part I

The False Map Of Happiness

Chapter 1

Pleasure As Repetition

The first false map of happiness is not crude indulgence. It is more precise than that. In the San Diego dialogue between J. Krishnamurti and Dr. Alan W. Anderson, the inquiry enters through a familiar uncertainty: pleasure, enjoyment, delight, joy, and happiness seem to belong together. Ordinary language lets them lean toward one another. A person may speak of being pleased, of enjoying, of joy, as though these were degrees of one movement.

Krishnamurti asks that the assumption be slowed down. The question is not whether the words are related. The question is whether pleasure has any actual continuity with joy or happiness. We can write the opening uncertainty as a deliberately unresolved relation:

$$\text{pleasure} \quad ? \quad \text{enjoyment} \quad ? \quad \text{joy} \quad ? \quad \text{happiness}. \quad (1.1)$$

The question marks are essential. This book begins by refusing to let vocabulary answer an inward question.

1.1 Pleasure Is Not Defined By Its Object

Krishnamurti's first move is to remove the comfort of noble examples. Pleasure may appear in eating, walking, money, sex, possession, knowledge, the idea of God, the wish to hurt, the wish to dominate, or the brutality of political power. The object changes. The movement remains recognizable.

The working distinction is:

$$\text{pleasure} = \text{the movement of thought in a direction}. \quad (1.2)$$

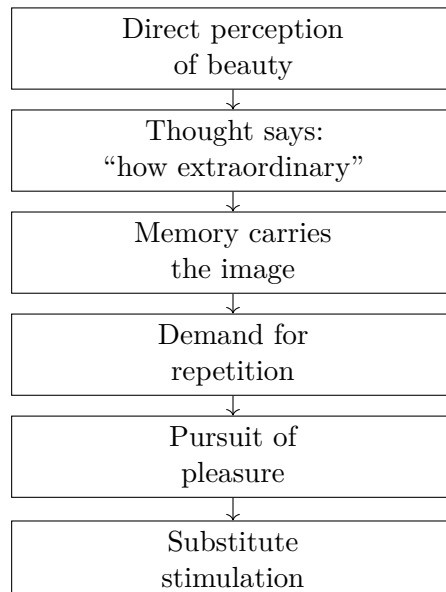
This is not a psychological law. It is a compact way of preserving the dialogue's order. Pleasure is sustained, nourished, and kept going. It moves toward having, repeating, continuing, or defending.

The same structure appears in possession:

$$\text{object seen or held} \longrightarrow \text{wanting it}, \quad (1.3)$$

$$\text{wanting it} \longrightarrow \text{possession}, \quad (1.4)$$

$$\text{possession} \longrightarrow \text{pleasure sustained}. \quad (1.5)$$



Transcript-based reconstruction of the pleasure sequence in the tree example.

When this movement is obstructed, Krishnamurti names its consequence:

$$\text{thwarted pleasure} \longrightarrow \text{frustration} \longrightarrow \text{anger, jealousy, violence.} \quad (1.6)$$

Pleasure, in this sense, is not made harmless by being called spiritual, cultural, romantic, or respectable. Its structure has to be read.

1.2 The Tree And The Demand For More

The central example is quiet: a single tree on a hill, green meadow, water, deer, flowers, shadow. There is direct perception. One sees. In that first seeing there is no possession, no inward collector, no thought saying that this must be stored.

Then one turns away. Thought enters and says that it was extraordinary. It asks to have it again. The first perception is now carried forward as memory, image, demand, and pursuit:

$$\text{perception} \longrightarrow \text{thought} \longrightarrow \text{memory} \longrightarrow \text{repetition} \longrightarrow \text{pursuit.} \quad (1.7)$$

This is the spine of the inquiry. The pleasure is not in the original seeing of the tree. Pleasure begins when thought takes what was seen and asks for continuity.

Anderson's examples of encore and festival widen the case. Repetition is not only private. A culture can organize itself around the attempt to repeat intensity: the encore, the festival, the cycle of living it up and living it down. Krishnamurti accepts this as the same movement. Thought nourishes pleasure and gives it direction.

1.3 Question & Answer

Question. When does enjoyment become pleasure?

Term	Working distinction
Pleasure	Thought-sustained movement in a direction; linked to memory, repetition, and pursuit.
Enjoyment	Immediate enjoyment; becomes pleasure when thought demands more.
Delight	Direct freshness, not yet organized as pursuit.
Joy	Not invited, not repeated by will, not a continuity of pleasure.
Happiness	Not known as an object while present; named only afterward.

Transcript-based distinction among the opening terms.

Answer. Enjoyment becomes pleasure when thought says, “I have enjoyed it; I must have more of it.” The change is not in the original enjoying. It is in the entry of thought, memory, image, demand, and direction.

Question. Does pleasure therefore become joy or happiness if refined?

Answer. In this dialogue, no continuity is granted. Pleasure belongs to thought moving in a direction. Joy and happiness are not invited, repeated, accumulated, or possessed. One may name happiness afterward, but in the moment itself it is not held as an object.

1.4 Attention Instead Of Control

The inquiry then raises its practical obstacle. If thought turns enjoyment into the pursuit of pleasure, should thought be controlled? Krishnamurti presents the traditional religious answer in order to reject it. Control means suppression, conflict, and fragmentation. It is still thought acting upon thought:

$$\text{thought interferes} \longrightarrow \text{control thought} \longrightarrow \text{suppression, conflict, fragmentation.} \quad (1.8)$$

The alternative is not carelessness. It is complete attention. Anderson clarifies that this does not mean muscular effort or forced concentration. Krishnamurti’s phrase is simpler: be wholly there. In such attention, thought does not enter as the demand for repetition:

$$\text{complete attention} \longrightarrow \text{no demand for repetition} \longrightarrow \text{action without control.} \quad (1.9)$$

1.4.1 Question & Answer

Question. If thought interferes with enjoyment, must thought be controlled?

Answer. No. Control belongs to the same divided movement. Krishnamurti’s answer is attention, not as a method, practice, or cultivated skill, but as whole seeing.

The poisonous bottle example gives the point its sharpest form. If one really sees that the bottle is poisonous, there is no need to control oneself into not drinking. Clear perception is already action. Control becomes necessary only when the label has not been read clearly.

$$\text{watching} \equiv \text{discipline} \equiv \text{action}. \quad (1.10)$$

The equivalence sign is only a notation for the spoken compression. It means that actual watching is not a preliminary to discipline or action. In the seeing itself there is order.

1.5 The Refusal Of Inner Possession

Anderson then tries to name a support behind this intelligence, some abiding source that sustains the person. Krishnamurti refuses the formulation. It opens the door to God, higher self, Atman, or a permanent inward entity. The refusal matters because it prevents attention from becoming doctrine.

The safer relation is:

$$\text{observation} + \text{attention} + \text{careful seeing} \longrightarrow \text{intelligence}. \quad (1.11)$$

Even this arrow must be read cautiously. Observation is not a technique for manufacturing intelligence. In actual seeing, intelligence is present.

This refusal continues in the story of the monk by the sea. The monk says he has arrived because he has controlled his senses, body, thoughts, and desires. Krishnamurti asks whether one can hold the sea in one's hand. When the water is held, it is no longer the sea. The same is true of the breeze and the earth. What is held may be only words. The story exposes a subtler pleasure: the pleasure of spiritual achievement, possession, and arrival.

1.6 Discipline Means Learning

Once control and possession are set aside, discipline must be redefined. In the ordinary religious sense, discipline often means conformity, suppression, practice, or adjustment to a pattern. Krishnamurti returns the word to learning:

$$\text{discipline} = \text{learning}. \quad (1.12)$$

Learning here is not accumulation. It is the active capacity to hear, see, and observe. A cultivated capacity may take time, but perception in this inquiry does not:

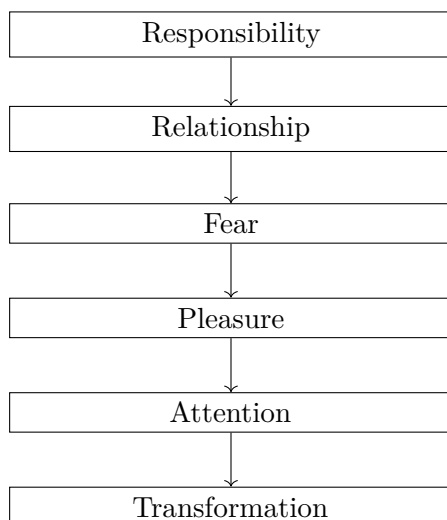
$$\text{cultivated capacity} \sim \text{time}, \quad (1.13)$$

$$\text{perception} \not\sim \text{time}. \quad (1.14)$$

Anderson notices the reversal. We commonly imagine perception perfected at the end of practice. Krishnamurti reverses the order: freedom is not at the end, but at the beginning. Observation, learning, and action occur together:

$$\text{seeing} + \text{learning} + \text{acting} \text{ occur together}. \quad (1.15)$$

This is why learning about pleasure brings its own order. It is not imposed order. It is the order that appears when the movement has been read.



Transcript-based reconstruction of Krishnamurti's closing map of the inquiry.

1.7 A Map For The Book

Near the end of the dialogue, Krishnamurti gathers the wider inquiry as a map: responsibility, relationship, fear, pleasure, attention, transformation. This first chapter therefore does more than answer whether pleasure brings happiness. It establishes the method of the whole book: read the movement exactly, without authority, without interpretation, without turning insight into possession.

The answer to the title question is therefore not a moral condemnation of pleasure. Pleasure is understood as repetition, continuity, and pursuit. Enjoyment can end as it happens. Happiness and joy are lost when thought tries to continue them. Attention reads the movement as it occurs, and in that reading the false map begins to lose its authority.

Chapter 2

Knowledge As The Past

The first false map was pleasure pursued as continuity. The second is more subtle: knowledge carried inwardly as security. In the San Diego conversation on knowledge and the transformation of man, Krishnamurti does not begin with epistemology. He begins with the state of the world: cultural degeneration, religious authority without religious spirit, political and economic confusion, misery, sorrow, and a human concern that often remains superficial even when it speaks about serious public problems.

The inquiry into knowledge is therefore not academic. It is forced by disorder. If the world is confused, and if human beings have made that world, then the question is whether the human being can change radically. The relation can be written only as a guide to the order of the dialogue:

$$\text{world disorder} \longrightarrow \text{question of human transformation.} \quad (2.1)$$

The arrow is not a doctrine of social causation. It marks the pressure of the inquiry: first one sees disorder; then one asks what, in the human being, can actually change.

2.1 The Human Being And The Whole

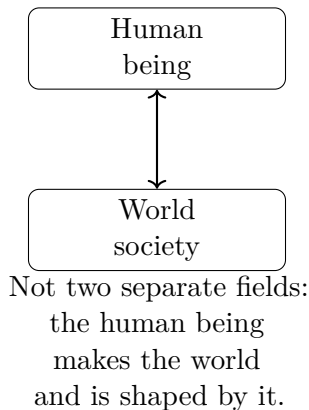
Anderson first names the issue as individual responsibility. Krishnamurti immediately corrects the word “individual.” Ordinarily, an individual is one person among others, a countable social unit. But the word also means undivided. A fragmented human being, however respectable, successful, or educated, is not yet individual in that deeper sense.

$$\text{individual}_{\text{ordinary}} = \text{one separate person,} \quad (2.2)$$

$$\text{individual}_{\text{qualitative}} = \text{undivided, whole, unfragmented.} \quad (2.3)$$

This distinction matters for the whole book. The inquiry into happiness is not about a private person collecting better inward experiences. Krishnamurti connects wholeness with sanity, health, and holiness. That language should not be made devotional. It points to a human being no longer broken into contradiction, fear, desire, belief, and opposing fragments.

Responsibility then becomes more exact. It is not guilt, nor a vague wish to improve. Krishnamurti gives it the tone of attention, care, and diligence. Responsibility is not handed to the mass, the



Transcript-based reconstruction of the lecture's non-separation claim.

priest, the church, the temple, the mosque, the politician, the businessman, or the scientist. It belongs to the human being who sees the disorder.

2.1.1 Question & Answer

Question. If transformation begins with each human being, is the inquiry merely private?

Answer. No. Krishnamurti answers by refusing the separation between the one and the whole. Human beings everywhere face sorrow, fear, livelihood, relationship, survival, life, and death. These are not essentially eastern or western problems. They are human problems.

So the beginning is with each human being, but not with an isolated self. The human being is already in relation to the whole of mankind. This prevents two evasions: one cannot hide behind collective change, and one cannot reduce transformation to private self-improvement.

2.2 The Human Being Is The World

The central claim of the dialogue is stark:

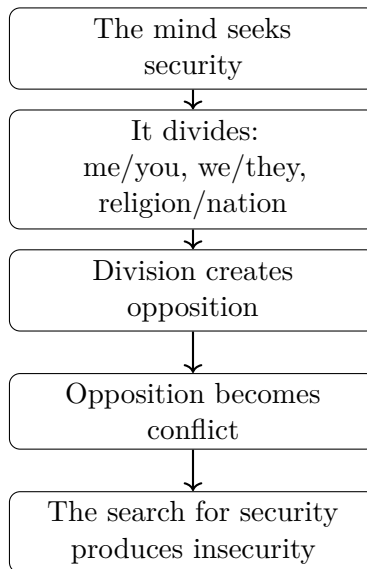
$$\text{human being} \leftrightarrow \text{world}. \quad (2.4)$$

This is not merely the claim that individuals influence society and society influences individuals. Krishnamurti's formulation is stronger: the human being is the world, and the world is the human being. Human beings have created society through greed, anger, violence, brutality, pettiness, fear, ambition, and the search for security. At the same time, each human being is shaped by culture, tradition, language, religion, and social order.

This is why a change of environment or structure cannot by itself answer the question. Krishnamurti names the old hope: change the environment and man will change. He says that it has not succeeded. Surface reform may polish the outside, but it does not necessarily touch the root of the mind.

$$\text{surface reform} \neq \text{root transformation}, \quad (2.5)$$

$$\text{change of structure} \not\Rightarrow \text{change of the human being}. \quad (2.6)$$



Transcript-based reconstruction of division as false security.

The point is not that social structures do not matter. The point is that they are not separate from the human mind that creates and inhabits them. The outward and inward are not two independent orders.

2.3 Division And The Search For Security

Once the human being and the world are not treated as separate, division becomes the next false map. The mind divides the physical world as East and West; it divides religion as Christian, Hindu, Muslim, Buddhist; it divides political life into capitalist, socialist, communist; it divides daily life into we and they, I and you.

Krishnamurti gives the relation with almost law-like force:

$$\text{division} \longrightarrow \text{conflict}. \quad (2.7)$$

This should remain an observation from the dialogue, not a formal theorem. Its force comes from the examples: religion, nationality, ideology, group identity, and the self's separation from another.

The deeper movement is that division promises security. The mind says “my nation,” “my religion,” “my belief,” “my group,” and feels protected. But the protection is illusory. The division produces opposition, and opposition produces insecurity.

Anderson's scriptural example sharpens the question of time. Doing truth and coming to light are not presented as an if-then sequence. The important point for the book is concurrency:

$$\text{action} \parallel \text{understanding}. \quad (2.8)$$

The symbol is only shorthand. It means that understanding is not postponed until after action, and action is not the delayed reward for first accepting a theory.

Practical knowledge	Skill, technology, language, memory, navigation, calculation, and ordinary functioning. This has its place.
Psychological knowledge	Accumulated image, hurt, praise, insult, flattery, belief, tradition, and remembered injury. This carries the past into relationship.

Transcript-based distinction between knowledge that functions and knowledge that becomes image.

2.3.1 Question & Answer

Question. Can the conditioned mind renew itself now?

Answer. Krishnamurti asks whether the mind, conditioned for millennia and loaded with knowledge, can regenerate now. His phrase “reincarnate now” should be read carefully. In this dialogue it means immediate renewal or regeneration, not a doctrine about literal rebirth.

The answer is not a method. The lecture sharpens the obstacle: the mind has divided the world in search of security, and it has accumulated knowledge as tradition, belief, image, and past. Therefore the next question is unavoidable: what place has knowledge in transformation?

2.4 Knowledge Has Its Place

Krishnamurti does not say that knowledge is useless. He explicitly says knowledge has its place. Practical knowledge is necessary: technological knowledge, physical knowledge, navigational knowledge, ordinary knowing where one is going. The distinction is between practical knowledge and psychological dependence on the known.

The question is what place knowledge has in changing the quality of a mind that is violent, petty, selfish, greedy, ambitious, and afraid. That question cannot be answered by condemning all knowledge. It can only be answered by seeing the limit of knowledge.

2.5 Experience, Mark, Memory, Knowledge

Krishnamurti begins with what is generally accepted as knowledge: experience. Experience leaves a mark; the mark becomes memory; memory is accumulated as knowledge.

$$\text{experience} \longrightarrow \text{mark} \longrightarrow \text{memory} \longrightarrow \text{knowledge.} \quad (2.9)$$

Then comes the decisive identification:

$$\text{knowledge} = \text{the known,} \quad (2.10)$$

$$\text{the known} = \text{the past,} \quad (2.11)$$

$$\therefore \text{knowledge} = \text{the past.} \quad (2.12)$$

This is conceptual notation, not a formal theory. Its purpose is to keep the sequence exact. Knowledge may be used in the present, but inwardly it has its roots in the past.

The practical difficulty appears when the past becomes the interpreter of the present:

$$\text{present encounter} + \text{past record} \longrightarrow \text{old interpretation.} \quad (2.13)$$

Then the new is not met as new. The present is translated through what has already been known.

2.5.1 Question & Answer

Question. If knowledge has a legitimate place, why must there be freedom from the known?

Answer. Because the issue is not practical functioning. It is psychological continuity. The mind lives on accumulated marks: praise, insult, hurt, fear, belief, and tradition. When those marks become the measure of the present, the past is meeting the present.

The inquiry is therefore not whether one should forget how to speak, build, travel, or repair. It is whether the mind can be free of the inward authority of the past where relationship, fear, and transformation are concerned.

2.6 Image Blocks Relationship

The most concrete example is relational. I meet you yesterday. That meeting leaves an image. Today I meet you again, but the image meets you. In that movement, there is no direct relationship.

$$\text{image} = \text{knowledge} = \text{tradition} = \text{past.} \quad (2.14)$$

The image is not a neutral mental picture. In this dialogue it is the accumulated past operating in relationship. Praise, insult, flattery, hurt, a gesture, a word, or an actual act may leave a mark. If the mark becomes image, then the next meeting is already distorted.

Krishnamurti does not deny that the brain records. He says the brain records all the time. The exact question is whether there can be necessary recording without psychological image:

$$\text{necessary recording} \not\rightarrow \text{psychological image.} \quad (2.15)$$

This is left as an open problem. The lecture does not convert it into a practice.

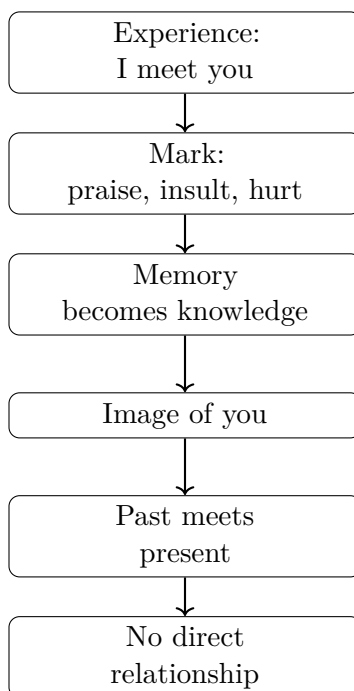
2.7 The Word Is Not The Thing

The closing movement returns to theory, religion, tradition, and description. Religion as it commonly exists is described as propaganda, belief, idolatry, fear, and division. In that sense, it is not transformation but another movement of thought.

The negation is simple and central:

$$\text{word} \neq \text{thing,} \quad (2.16)$$

$$\text{description} \neq \text{described.} \quad (2.17)$$



Transcript-based reconstruction of the movement from experience to image and blocked relationship.

This extends the same false-map structure. Pleasure becomes false when thought demands continuity. Knowledge becomes false inwardly when the past interprets the present. Religion and theory become false when description replaces what is.

When the mind is concerned with theories, speculations, and beliefs, action is postponed. When it is confronted with what is, action is possible. The next step of the book must therefore keep this edge open: not verbal freedom, not speculative freedom, but actual freedom from the known.